

The Broken MIRROR

Kamila Shamsie's new novel is populated by lives displaced by a cruel history

| By Geeta Doctor |



BURNT SHADOWS
by KAMILA SHAMSIE
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The images swirl out of the pages of Kamila Shamsie's novel like the fragments of a poem, a Sufi poem perhaps by Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan, repetitive and insistent with the memory of desire and loss. There is nothing here she describes that we don't know and remember. She has taken some of the most dramatic and bitterly recollected moments of history and pieced them together in a pattern that is as densely woven and dyed in the sweat and blood of the people who have left them behind. This is the story of refugees from some of the most harrowing events of the 20th Century's devastating legacy of casual dislocation and annihilation. You can take your pick: the Nagasaki bombing; the twin exodus of the Partition; the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan; the coming of the Taliban and 9/11.

It is also a survivor's tale. For Shamsie does not dwell on the horror as much as recount its effects as they are imprinted on the bodies of her characters like the recurring images of the burnt-out shadows of her title, of the charred remains of the three black flying cranes patterned on the white background of a silk kimono that Hiroko Tanaka slips on before she is blinded by the light of a thousand suns. In a sense, we experience the sequence of events from the viewpoint of Hiroko, a peripatetic Japanese

woman with a gift for languages that she gives to her son Raza, who is born in Karachi.

Shamsie has obviously imbibed the current mantra—write local, think global. For she writes from a perspective that is so wide it appears to include the world in its grasp. At the same time, she knows that what matters are those small luminous fragments that linger in the human heart. Some time ago while she was in India, she had said, half amused, having been brought up on English classics, it had not occurred to her that it was possible for her to write about a place as ordinary as Karachi, until she had read the great liberator of the subcontinental imagination, Rushdie. "I was puzzled. He had referred to Karachi as the 'city of acquiescence'. There was nothing acquiescent about it to me. That's when I realised that you don't have to agree with everything you read."

She had also underlined her concerns at being described as a Pakistani writer. It would not be out of place to mention that her mother Muneeza Shamsie has edited a book on Pakistani writers or that her grand-aunt Attiya Hosain wrote a luminous account of pre-Partition Lucknow in *Sunlight on a Broken Column*. It is hardly surprising then that one hears all kinds of echoes in the pages of Shamsie's latest oeuvre, from E.M. Forster's Dr Aziz who is transformed into the young Sajjad Ashraf, a reluctant refugee from Old Delhi, to the faint powdery fragrance of the pansies growing in a novel by Nayantara Sahgal, as Shamsie locates the second section of her story in the English gardens of Lutyens' Delhi, to Kipling sending his Kim out in the Great Game to Charles Dickens and a Sidney Cartonesque finale, when Raza confronts his demons. He is perhaps the weakest link in the narrative.

Shamsie's concern is no longer with any particular voice or nationality but in a call to our common humanity. One imagines Shamsie standing on a precipice and blowing a silver trumpet. She creates the most marvellous images that spin through the air like the moment when a silver fox creeps through the grass of Himalayan hillside as Hiroko finds that there is a future for her after all. Then again as the vision fades and the nuclear night brings with it the betrayals and doubts, Shamsie asks us: will there be a future for us? ■



SUMEETINDER SINGH

KAMILA SHAMSIE